

Chapter 69-1

This was an extremely restrained touch.

The lips were ice-cold, yet they warmed the instant they pressed down.

The black umbrella appeared solemn and dignified in the cemetery. Liang Shi's eyes were instantly shrouded and invaded by darkness, the umbrella top pressing against the crown of her head. The hand gripping the umbrella handle tightened, her fair hand immediately tensing, her body stiffening.

But her emotions grew infinitely heavy with the rain, becoming low along with Xu Qingzhu's emotions.

The sound of rain and footsteps overlapped.

Unhurried footsteps passed by their sides, the large umbrella enveloping both of them.

No one could see their faces clearly.

Liang Shi's fingertips gently landed at the corner of Xu Qingzhu's eye, wiping away that tear that had been condensed by the cold air.

The hand holding the umbrella was grasped by Xu Qingzhu, but her hand was too cold.

Liang Shi turned her own hand over, covering the back of her hand, trying to pass her a trace of warmth.

At the same time, in this bitter cold wind, she closed her eyes, her other hand falling on the back of Xu Qingzhu's head, gently stroking the crown of her head.

Fine threads of rain entwined in the wind, condensing into water droplets along the direction of the umbrella ribs.

Patter—

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Xu Qingzhu retreated when she was just one step away from the truth. Liang Shi shielded her from all the slanting wind and cold rain.

In that moment, Liang Shi thought, this mission could be left undone.

Not because she felt it couldn't be completed, but purely out of protecting Xu Qingzhu's tottering faith.

Standing outside the door of truth, Xu Qingzhu was fragile and distant, like a breakable porcelain doll.

So Liang Shi chose to accompany her in burying those truths together.

Their current life was the truth.

There was no deeper meaning.

Until the footsteps disappeared, Xu Qingzhu slowly opened her eyes. In the dimness, she and Liang Shi looked at each other.

She lightly licked her lips, the corners of her mouth turning up, but in her eyes was a bottomless sadness.

Liang Shi's hand gently patted the crown of her head, lowering her voice to coax softly: "You stand here, and I'll go pick up the bracelet for you, okay?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't speak.

Liang Shi released the hand holding hers, then bent down and emerged from under the umbrella.

The rain fell on her clothes and the tips of her hair, but she didn't feel cold. The large black umbrella enveloped the thin Xu Qingzhu within it, as if isolating a cold little world.

Liang Shi worried about Xu Qingzhu's emotions, and even called out to her in the rain: "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu let out a muffled single syllable: "Mm?"

Liang Shi's ears were filled with the sound of wind and rain—she couldn't hear at all—but as she walked forward, she said: "Stand still and don't move. Wait for me."

Xu Qingzhu stood lonely under the black umbrella. She also wore all black, blending into this lonely and solemn cemetery.

Her entire being was lifeless.

She lowered her eyelids, lightly pressing her lips together, watching the lines of rain meandering down the gray stone slabs.

Xu Qingzhu's body trembled uncontrollably. In her mind, it was as if countless threads were growing in a tangled mess, unbridled, heading toward deeper places.

It seemed like a bottomless abyss—once fallen in, there would be no redemption.

She wanted to close her eyes, but it was as if someone was forcefully compelling her to keep them open.

The string in her brain called reason was pulled tighter and tighter. Since the last relapse at the hospital, she hadn't experienced this similar emotion again.

It felt like she could barely hold on anymore.

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Xu Qingzhu's breathing became tense, and she couldn't grip the umbrella tightly. The umbrella tilted from her shoulder, half her body exposed to the rain.

Her hands completely lost their strength, and the umbrella fell to the ground, rolling two circles before stopping.

Just as the string in her mind was about to snap, Liang Shi ran over quickly and hugged her tightly.

Liang Shi held her entire person in her embrace, saying in a low voice: "Xu Qingzhu, it's okay."

Her gentle voice fell into Xu Qingzhu's ears, "I'm here."

Memory seemed to return to many years ago, when that gentle older sister¹ said to her: "It's alright, don't be afraid."

Footnotes:

¹ 姐姐 (jiějie) - Older sister: A term that can refer to one's biological older sister, but is also commonly used in Chinese culture to address any older female figure with affection and respect. In this context, it refers to a significant person from Xu Qingzhu's past who played a protective, caring role in her life.